

Recording a Route Without Satellites

Speed from Vibration and Direction from Turns on a Smartphone, Measured Against GPS

Yu Yao-Hsing

euler.yu@gmail.com

Abstract

When GPS is lost — in a tunnel, an underground car park or an aircraft — a phone can still draw the route it travels. This paper describes a system that reads *speed* from how the vehicle shakes and *direction* from the phone’s gyroscope, accelerometer and magnetometer, using GPS for nothing but the first point, and measures it against GPS on a motorcycle, in a car, on foot and on a plane. Every recording was replayed through the newest version from its raw sensor data, with GPS used only as the answer key: 76 motorcycle and car journeys (20 hours, 343 km that GPS could check), 45 straight stretches and seven longer walks on foot, and one flight. Direction was within 30° of GPS 75% of the time on a motorcycle, 81% in a car, 93% on foot and 99% on the plane, and the median route was turned 11° on a motorcycle and 16° in a car. Distance came out 12% short on a motorcycle, within 1% in a car and 4% long on foot. In the air, a network trained on 302 airline flights from NASA’s public flight recorder data, reading only the time since the takeoff roll and the phone’s tilt, raised the flight’s distance from 61% to 103%, and a store of examples from the same data to 99%; drawn with no GPS after the first point, the flight ended 16.1 km from where GPS did. A phone with no examples of its own starts with a small built-in network, which on recordings it had never seen was a little more accurate than a full store. We also report what each part of the direction method adds, where the system fails, and the approaches that did not work.

Keywords: dead reckoning; smartphone sensors; GNSS-denied navigation; vehicle speed estimation; heading estimation; magnetometer

1 Introduction

A phone that loses GPS still knows a great deal about how it moves. Its accelerometer feels every push and every bump, its gyroscope measures every turn, its magnetometer senses north, and its barometer feels height. In principle that is enough to keep drawing a route through a tunnel, an underground car park or a flight. In practice two things make it hard.

The first is *speed*. Adding up acceleration, the textbook answer, does not work on a phone: its small sensor errors grow into kilometres within minutes [1, 2]. The second is *direction*. The gyroscope measures turns but not north; the magnetometer measures north but in a vehicle it is disturbed by steel, and in any case it gives the direction the *phone* points, not the direction of travel, which differ by however the phone happens to sit in a pocket or a holder [3].

This paper describes a system built around those two problems, running as a mode of an ordinary iPhone app, and measures how well it works. Its contributions are:

- **A complete route recorder that uses GPS for the first point only.** Speed comes from a fingerprint of the vehicle’s vibration, looked up in a store of the phone’s own earlier trips or, on a new phone, answered by a small built-in network. Direction comes from the vehicle’s turns, which reveal how the phone sits, on top of a heading whose slow drift is

measured at stops and whose starting error is corrected by the magnetometer whenever the magnetic field can be trusted (Section 3).

- **An evaluation against GPS that reflects the newest version.** Every recording was replayed through the current method from its raw sensor data, and every result is split by what was moving: a motorcycle, a car, a person walking or a plane (Sections 4 and 5). Appendix A lists every journey.
- **An account of what matters.** We measure what each part of the direction method adds (Section 5.5), where the system goes wrong, and the approaches that did not work (Section 6).

2 Related work

Inertial navigation. Integrating acceleration twice gives position, but the error grows quickly — with the square of time for an accelerometer bias and faster still for a gyroscope bias [1]; smartphone accelerometers and gyroscopes carry biases and noise large enough to make unaided integration useless within minutes [2]. Practical systems therefore constrain the problem.

Pedestrian dead reckoning. For walking, the usual constraint is the step: count steps, estimate their length and their direction [4]. A sensor on the foot can reset its velocity at every stance [5]; a phone in a pocket cannot, and its heading depends on how it is held, which several methods try to resolve [3]. Our walking mode follows the step-counting tradition; its direction method is our own.

Orientation. Orientation filters fuse gyroscope, accelerometer and magnetometer readings [6], and on an iPhone Apple’s Core Motion provides one. Such filters assume gravity is the only steady force, so a vehicle’s sustained acceleration — a takeoff roll — is mistaken for a tilt [7]. We found two more practical problems with the built-in heading, in a pocket and in a car (Section 3.2).

Vehicle speed from vibration. Road vibration changes with speed, and learned models can read speed from accelerometer data alone [8]. Our speed model is of that kind, but it learns continuously from the phone’s own trips and must work for a phone in a trouser pocket on a motorcycle as well as in a car.

3 Method

A route is a series of short steps, one per second. Each step needs a length and a direction; with GPS both come from satellites, here both come from the phone (Figure 1).

3.1 Speed

A fingerprint of the vibration. Every second the phone takes the last five seconds of up-and-down acceleration, measured 50 times a second, and reduces it to eleven numbers: the energy of the shaking in nine frequency ranges and two measures of its overall strength. A vehicle shakes differently at different speeds, and the fingerprint captures that.

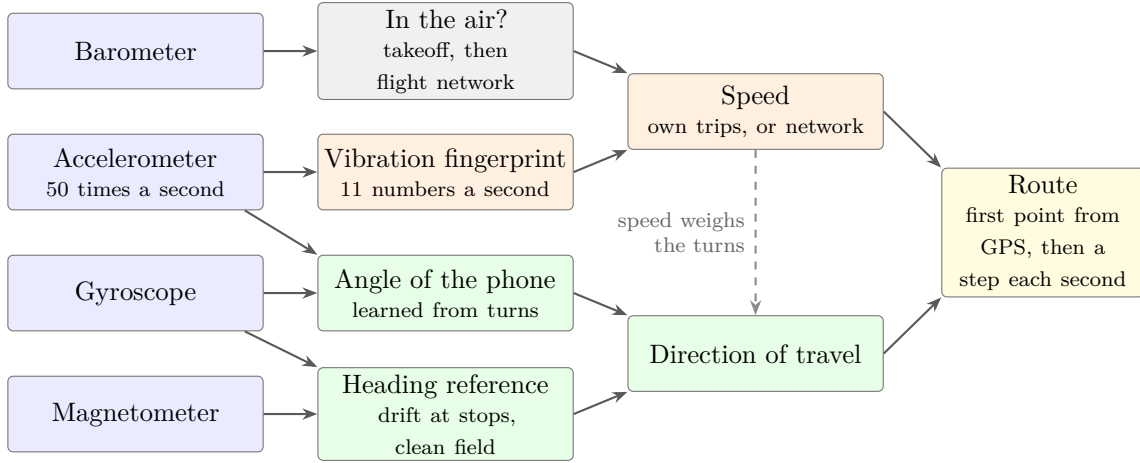


Figure 1. The system. Speed comes from the accelerometer’s vibration, or in the air from integrating the takeoff and then from a network trained on airline flights; direction combines the angle of the phone, learned from the gyroscope’s turns and the push felt in them, with a heading reference. GPS gives the first point and nothing else.

A store of the phone’s own trips. Whenever GPS is available the phone stores fingerprints with the speed GPS measured at that moment, keeping up to 4,000. Without GPS it looks up the 12 stored fingerprints closest to the current one and averages their speeds, nearer ones counting more:

$$\hat{v} = \frac{\sum_{j=1}^{12} v_j / d_j^2}{\sum_{j=1}^{12} 1 / d_j^2}, \quad (1)$$

where v_j is a stored speed and d_j the distance between fingerprints. If even the closest stored fingerprint is far away, the phone gives no answer rather than a guess. Averaging pulls every answer toward the middle, so a correction learned from the stored examples stretches the answers back out.

A starting network. A new phone has no examples, so until it holds 3,000 it uses a small network (11 inputs, two layers of 32, one output) trained on recorded trips and shipped with the app. It needs nothing from the current trip, and it declines a fingerprint unlike anything it was trained on.

Stops and hands. A stopped vehicle is recognised from the absence of shaking, not from the speed model, which would read an idling engine as a crawl. A hand on the phone shakes it, and shaking reads as speed, so while the phone is being handled the speed may fall but not rise, and a phone held in the hand keeps the last speed measured before it was picked up.

In the air. A smooth cabin reads as standing still. In the air the phone instead measures the takeoff: from the last moment it was still, it follows its own turning with the gyroscope and adds up the push the accelerometer feels for up to two minutes. Core Motion’s own orientation cannot be used for this, because it takes a takeoff’s steady push for a tilt [7]. Integration beyond two minutes gathers too much error, so the phone used to hold the speed it had reached, which misses the speed-up in the climb.

After the takeoff: two flight engines. What a phone in a cabin can still sense is how long ago the takeoff roll began and how it is tilted: an aircraft climbs nose-up and levels off as it reaches cruise. The phone measures its tilt once a second against the way gravity pointed at the

still moment before the roll, and forms four inputs: minutes since the roll began, the average tilt over the last minute and the last five minutes, and the tilt added up since the roll began. Two engines turn these into a speed, in the same pair as on the ground. The *flight network* has four inputs, two layers of 32 and one output. The *flight store* holds 4,000 examples and answers like the phone's store, averaging the 12 nearest with weights $1/d^2$. Both were trained offline on NASA's public flight recorder data (Section 4), with the recorded ground speed as the answer. They use no GPS and nothing from the current trip, and inputs beyond the range of the training flights are held at its edge. The network is used, the store stands in if the network is missing, and the air examples from the phone's own earlier flights take precedence when there are any. None of this is used on the ground.

3.2 Direction

A heading reference. The phone's built-in heading follows a direction inside the phone that depends on how it is held, and when that direction points nearly straight down — a phone head-down at an angle in a trouser pocket — it scattered by about 49° a minute although the phone did not move. The system therefore computes its own heading from the phone's orientation, using whichever edge of the phone lies closest to level; in the same position that heading scattered by about 1° a minute.

Drift, measured at stops. In a car the heading also drifts slowly with the gyroscope's own bias, because the steel around it keeps the magnetometer from holding north: on one drive it turned 42° in 25 minutes with the phone fixed in place. A stopped car does not turn, so any turning the heading shows while the car is stopped and the phone still is drift. The phone measures it as a rate, at most 3° a minute, and takes the accumulated drift off every heading.

The magnetometer, when the field can be trusted. Core Motion also sets north once at the start, often wrongly inside a vehicle, and then follows the gyroscope. On one drive it began $20\text{--}26^\circ$ off while the magnetometer, read directly, put the phone within $1\text{--}5^\circ$ of the truth. So whenever the magnetic field looks like Earth's — between 25 and $65\ \mu\text{T}$, with its strength and dip steady for a minute — the phone compares the magnetometer's heading with its own and takes the difference, less the drift already measured, as the correction to where the heading started. Beside a MagSafe charger the phone read up to $2,600\ \mu\text{T}$ and nothing is taken from it.

The angle of the phone, from turns. The heading says where the phone points, not where the vehicle goes; the two differ by an angle β that depends on how the phone sits. In a turn the vehicle is pushed toward the inside of the curve, with a push equal to speed times turn rate, so comparing the sideways push the phone feels with the turning the gyroscope measures shows which way is forward. Written as complex numbers,

$$\hat{\beta} = \arg \left(\frac{\sum_R z_t}{\sum_R |v_t \omega_t|} + \frac{\sum_L z_t}{\sum_L |v_t \omega_t|} \right), \quad z_t = \frac{a_t}{|a_t|} i v_t \omega_t, \quad (2)$$

where a_t is the horizontal acceleration relative to the heading, written as its sideways and forward parts, v_t the speed, ω_t the turn rate, and R and L the seconds turning right and left. Braking into a corner and pulling away out of it lean the answer one way in right turns and the other way in left ones, so the two kinds are averaged apart. Only seconds above 14 km/h count, and only when the turn explains at least a tenth of the push; otherwise the push is braking or throttle, and a reversing car's push points backwards. The first estimate comes after 30 seconds of turning, and whenever the estimate improves the part of the ride already drawn is redrawn with it.

Table 1. The recordings. GPS km is the distance GPS could check; half-minutes are the stretches used for speed; direction is graded in recordings with at least 50 graded seconds.

	Record-ings	Hours	GPS km	Half-minutes	Direction rec. (s)	Routes	Phone
Motorcycle	39	11.1	177	818	40 (13,248)	41	trouser pocket
Car	37	8.9	166	757	27 (9,258)	28	pocket, flat or mount
Walking	17	—	1.9	45	7 (721)	—	pocket
Plane	1	0.24	74	—	1 (876)	—	cabin

Walking. Over four seconds the back-and-forth of the steps lines up with the direction of walking, and each push-off is sharper than each landing, which tells which end of that line is forward.

3.3 The route

After the first point, each second’s step is laid from the previous point along the current direction, for the distance the speed covers in that second. No later GPS position, course or speed enters the route, the heading or the decisions between walking and riding; the magnetic declination is taken once, at the first point. Appendix B lists every setting.

4 Data and evaluation

4.1 Recordings

All recordings were made by the author with one iPhone, mostly in one city, with the phone’s raw sensor readings saved — acceleration, rotation, orientation and, in the most recent ones, the magnetic field, 50 times a second — and GPS recorded alongside. Table 1 summarises them. A motorcycle and a car were told apart from the sensors themselves: in a turn a motorcycle leans and the phone leans with it, while a car stays level and the phone is pushed sideways; this agreed with every journey whose vehicle was known. Walking is the time the app was counting steps.

4.2 Airline flight recorder data

One flight is too few to learn the air speed from, so the two flight engines were trained on NASA’s public DASHlink archive of flight recorder data [9]: the recordings of one regional jet in airline service, of which 302 flights include a takeoff. Each flight was reduced to one value a second of the recorded ground speed and of the aircraft’s pitch and roll, from which its tilt from level follows as $\arccos(\cos \theta \cos \phi)$. The flights spent a median 48 minutes in the air (26 to 98 for the middle 80%), at a median ground speed of 656 km/h. Only the ground speed is an answer; the inputs are the four the phone forms itself, timed from the start of the takeoff roll, taken as the last moment under 30 knots before liftoff.

4.3 Replaying the newest version

So that every result describes the newest version, each recording was replayed through the current method from its raw sensor data:

- **Speed:** the same fingerprint, the same 12-neighbour average, refusals and correction, and the same rules for stops, a phone in the hand, and holding the last answer. The store holds

4,000 examples drawn at random from every *other* journey, so no journey is measured with its own GPS in the store. Each example keeps the same chance of being drawn whatever recordings are added, so a new recording changes the other journeys' stores only by its own examples. On twelve recent journeys the replay came out typically 6% shorter than what the app itself had drawn.

- **Direction:** the heading reference, drift correction, magnetometer correction (where the magnetic field was recorded), the angle learned from turns and the redrawing, with the replayed speed.
- **Starting network:** each recording measured by a network trained without it (the recordings split into eight groups), and the store tested holding only 60 to 4,000 examples.
- **Walking:** the step detector replayed on the recorded acceleration with the stride the phone had learned.
- **The flight:** the app's own code for the takeoff integration, the tilt and both flight engines, compiled and run on the flight's raw samples; its direction is replayed with that speed in the air, as the app has it.
- **Flight engines on NASA flights:** each flight measured by engines trained without it (the flights split into five groups), from the start of the roll to landing, against holding the speed two minutes into the roll.

Three inputs are taken from the recordings as they were: whether each second was walking or riding, Apple's motion classifier, and the car-park ramp flag. Cabin pressure was not recorded, so on the flight the moment the app would call it airborne was taken from the same integration's climb rate.

4.4 Measures

In a pocket GPS is itself accurate only to 10–40 m, so it is used over stretches long enough for that not to matter.

- **Speed and distance** are compared over half-minute stretches between GPS fixes better than 40 m: the straight distance GPS moved against the distance the system added. For walking, only straight stretches between fixes better than 25 m are used.
- **Direction** is compared every second: the bearing from the GPS position 15 s earlier to the one 15 s later, against the system's heading over the same half-minute (10 s for the plane).
- **Whole routes** are compared by finding the rotation and the size change that best lay the drawn route over the GPS track, pinned at the shared start, for routes of at least 1 km. The rotation is how far the route is turned; the size change how much too big or small it is; the drift is how far the drawn end lies from GPS's, as a share of the distance travelled.

4.5 Stretches left out

Six car journeys went into, started in or ended in underground car parks. There GPS kept claiming 10 m accuracy for positions it did not have — frozen while parked, wandering on the ramps — so those stretches, found from the barometer, are left out of every comparison. So are half-minutes that mix walking and riding, and those in which the app counted steps while GPS showed riding speed.

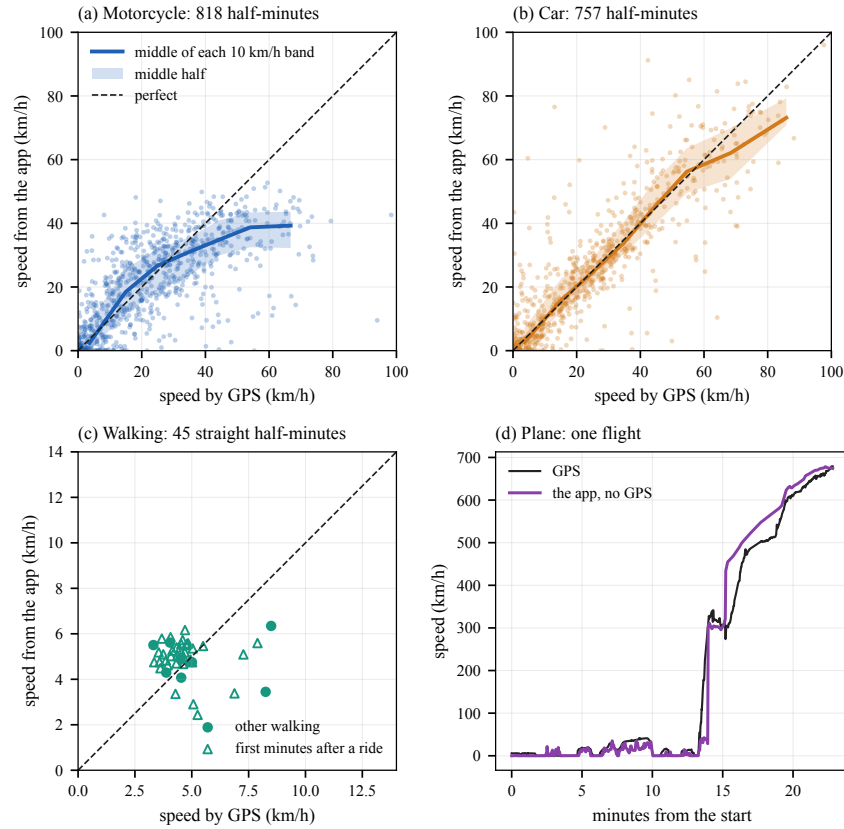


Figure 2. Speed from the app against GPS. (a, b) Each dot is a half-minute of riding; the line is the middle of each 10 km/h band and the shading the middle half. On the dashed line the two agree. (c) Straight half-minutes of walking; triangles are the first minutes after a ride. (d) One flight.

Table 2. Speed by GPS speed band: number of half-minutes, the middle GPS and app speeds, and the average error (km/h).

GPS band (km/h)	Motorcycle				Car			
	n	GPS	App	Error	n	GPS	App	Error
0–10	253	2.6	2.4	4.6	241	2.7	2.7	4.1
10–20	159	14.7	18.4	8.8	130	15.1	16.0	7.1
20–30	138	25.0	26.6	7.4	120	25.1	24.7	5.6
30–40	109	35.1	31.0	7.8	98	35.1	33.9	6.2
40–50	79	44.0	34.8	12.2	58	43.7	44.9	9.3
50–60	43	53.2	38.7	17.4	42	54.6	56.2	9.7
60–80	34	66.4	39.3	30.4	56	68.9	62.1	10.2
80+	3	98.4	37.7	71.9	12	87.1	72.3	43.1
All	818	19.9	21.1	9.0	757	20.5	22.5	6.9

5 Results

5.1 Speed

Figure 2 and Table 2 compare speed half-minute by half-minute.

- **Motorcycle** (818 half-minutes). The app squeezes the range: 10–20 km/h reads about 18, 20–30 km/h is close, and above that it reads ever lower: about 31 at 30–40 km/h and

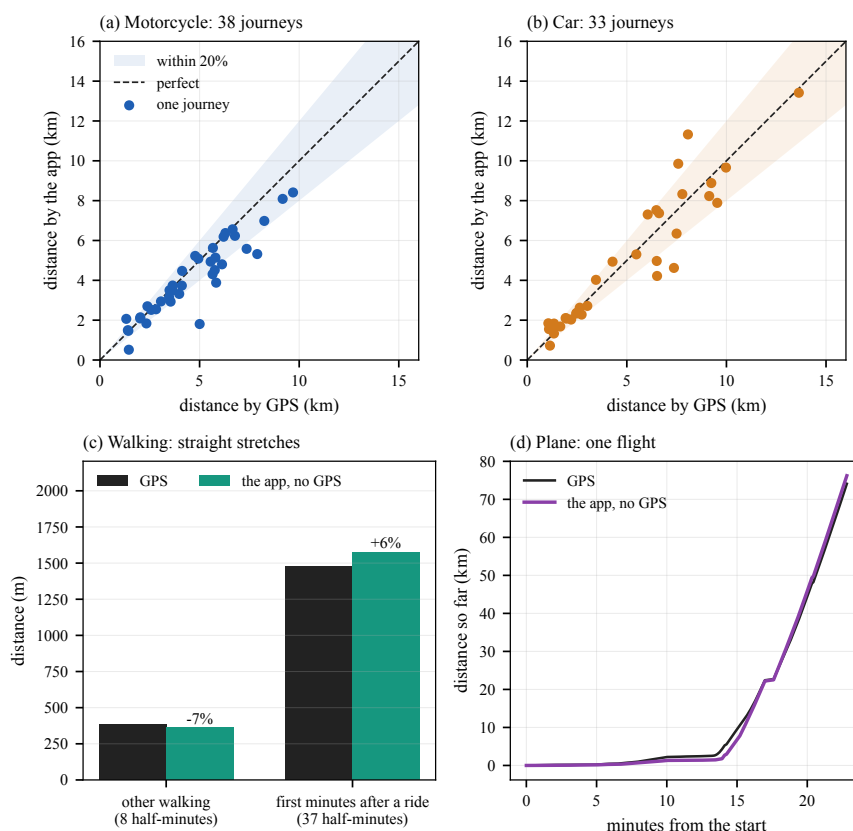


Figure 3. Distance by the app against GPS. (a, b) Each dot is one journey with at least 1 km that GPS could check; the shading is within 20%. (c) Straight stretches of walking, added up. (d) Distance so far on the flight.

about 39 where GPS measured 66 at 60–80 km/h. The squeeze comes from the averaging: when a fingerprint could belong to several speeds, the average lands in the middle. The average error is 9.0 km/h.

- **Car** (757 half-minutes). Much closer: from 10 to 60 km/h the middle reading is within about 2 km/h of GPS. Above that it reads low (62 where GPS measured 69, and 72 where it measured 87). The average error is 6.9 km/h.
- **Walking** (45 straight half-minutes). About 5.0 km/h where GPS measured 4.6.
- **Plane.** While taxiing the app reads about 13 km/h where GPS measured 18. In the air it measures the takeoff — 265 km/h forty seconds into the roll, where GPS measured 266 — and after two minutes the flight network takes over, reading about 570 km/h where GPS measured 510 three minutes later and 675 where it measured 670 near the end (Section 5.6).

5.2 Distance

On a motorcycle the app added 156 km where GPS measured 177 km, 12% short: the distance lost at high speed outweighs what is gained at low speed. In a car it added 167 km of 166 km, 0.3% long. Journey by journey the spread is wider (Table 3): 74% of motorcycle journeys and 67% of car journeys came within 20% of GPS. Walking came out 4% long, 7% long in the first minutes after a ride and 7% short at other times. The flight counted 76.2 of 74.1 km, where holding the takeoff speed had counted 45.2. Motorcycle and car together, the app added 323 km

Table 3. Distance against GPS. Total is the whole category; the median journey, the share within 10% and 20%, and the range use journeys with at least 1 km checked.

	Journeys	GPS km	App km	Total	Median journey	Within 10%	Within 20%	Range app/GPS
Motorcycle	39	176.5	156.1	−11.6%	−8.5%	53%	74%	0.36–1.57
Car	37	166.1	166.7	+0.3%	−0.7%	45%	67%	0.63–1.74
Walking	45 str.	1.87	1.93	+3.7%	after a ride	+6.5%, otherwise	−6.8%	
Plane	1	74	76	+2.9%	takeoff measured, then the flight network			

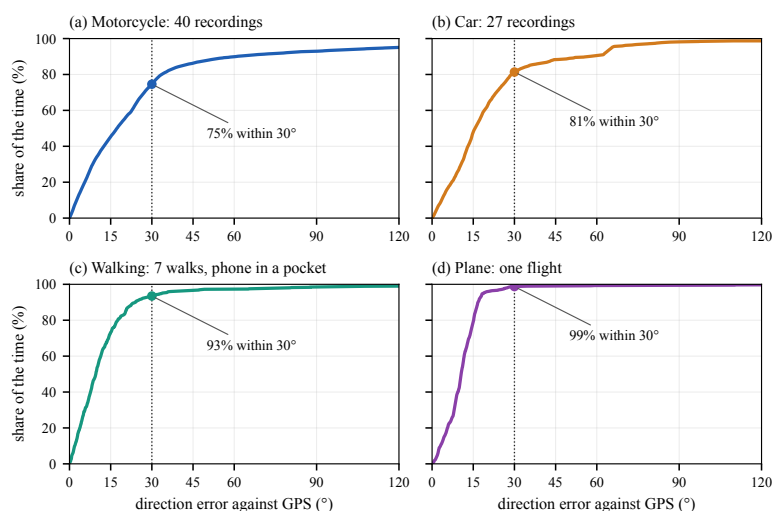


Figure 4. How often the direction is within a given angle of GPS, compared every second with a half-minute of GPS track (ten seconds for the plane).

where GPS measured 343 km, 5.8% short.

5.3 Direction

Direction holds up in every case (Figure 4, Table 4). The median error is 17° on a motorcycle, 16° in a car, 10° on foot and 11° on the plane; 75%, 81%, 93% and 99% of seconds are within 30° . The tails differ: one motorcycle second in ten is off by more than 61° , against 57° in a car, because a phone in a trouser pocket moves as the rider shifts.

Figure 5 follows the error through a ride. In the first minutes the angle of the phone is still being learned and the error is highest; it settles within a few minutes. In a car the full method stays below the compass-and-turns method alone for most of the drive, as drift correction and the magnetometer keep the heading reference in place; on a motorcycle the two are close, since a motorcycle's stops rarely hold the phone still enough to measure drift.

5.4 Whole routes

Figure 6 and Table 5 put speed and direction together. The median motorcycle route is turned 11° and 85% are within 30° ; the median car route is turned 15° and 79% are within 30° . Motorcycle routes come out small — a median 0.83 of the real size — partly because distance is short and partly because small direction errors fold the path; car routes have the right size (median 0.97). The drawn end lies a median 18% (motorcycle) and 14% (car) of the distance travelled from GPS's. Six routes are turned more than 45° ; five of them are under 3 km, with too few turns to learn the angle of the phone well.

Table 4. Direction error against GPS: the median, the 75th and 90th percentiles, and the share of graded seconds within 15°, 30° and 45°.

	Graded	Median	75th pct.	90th pct.	Within 15°	Within 30°	Within 45°
Motorcycle	40 rec., 13,248 s	17°	30°	61°	45%	75%	86%
Car	27 rec., 9,258 s	16°	26°	57°	48%	81%	88%
Walking	7 walks, 721 s	10°	16°	24°	73%	93%	97%
Plane	1 flight, 876 s	11°	14°	17°	79%	99%	99%

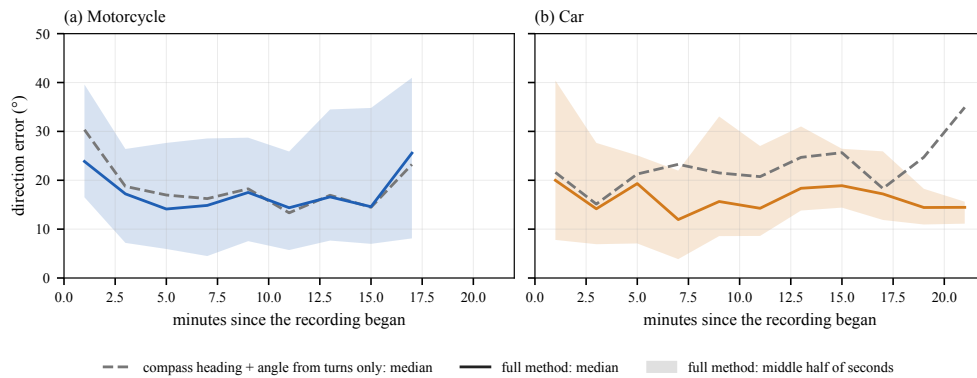
**Figure 5.** Direction error through a ride, in two-minute bins with at least 300 graded seconds: the full method against the compass heading with the angle learned from turns alone.

Figure 7 shows eight routes, chosen across the range of accuracy rather than the best ones: for each vehicle the routes at the 10th, 40th, 70th and 95th percentile of end drift.

5.5 What each part of the direction method adds

Table 6 replays every recording with the direction method built up one part at a time, graded exactly as above. For cars, drift measured at stops and the averaging of right and left turns matter most: together they take the share of seconds within 30° from 66% to 77% and routes within 30° from 71% to 79%, and cut the routes turned more than 45° from eight to six; the check that a turn explains the push adds a point and the magnetometer three more. For motorcycles every version is within a point or two. The flight, replayed with the speed the app has in the air, is within 30° 88% of the time with the first version and 99% once drift is measured at stops.

5.6 The flight

Figure 8 follows the flight with the same direction method as on the road, fed the speed the app itself has: the speed model on the ground, then the measured takeoff and the flight network. While taxiing the median error was 9° and in the air 12°. Eleven seconds were more than 30° off: one in the pushback, when the aircraft moves tail first while the method gives the way the nose points, and ten around the runway, stopped or just starting the roll, where the GPS track has no clear direction. In the climb the error grows slowly, to about 15° by the end of the recording.

Speed in the air is where the flight engines come in (Figure 9, Table 7). On the recorded flight the takeoff measurement reached 317 km/h and, held, counted 45.2 of the 74.1 km: the aircraft kept speeding up to 680 km/h. From two minutes into the roll the flight network read the climb from the phone's tilt and the time since the roll, and the flight counted 76.2 km (103%); with the flight store, 73.6 km (99%). The average speed error in the air fell from 196 km/h to

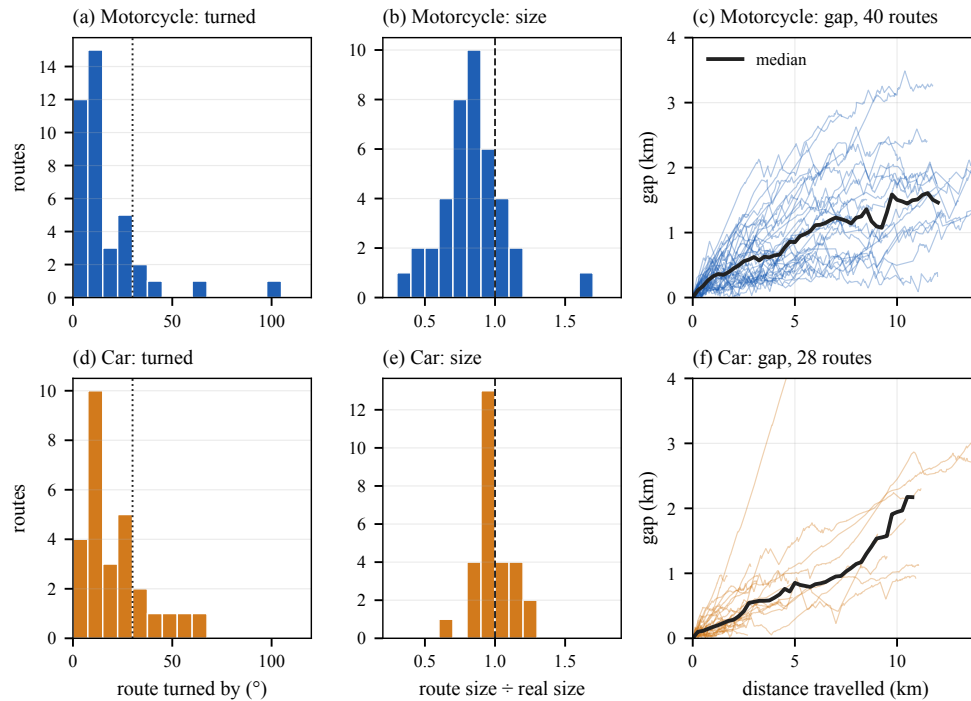


Figure 6. Routes drawn by the app against GPS. (a, d) How far each whole route is turned; the dotted line is 30° . (b, e) Its size relative to GPS. (c, f) How far the drawn position is from GPS as the journey goes on: one thin line per route, and the median.

Table 5. Whole routes against GPS.

			Whole route turned				Size		End drift
	Routes	GPS km	median	$\leq 15^\circ$	$\leq 30^\circ$	$> 45^\circ$	median	within 20%	median
Motorcycle	41	351	11°	66%	85%	3	0.83	54%	18%
Car	28	149	15°	50%	79%	3	0.97	89%	14%

38 and 37. The network reads high by about 50 km/h early in the climb, where this aircraft gained speed more slowly than the NASA jet typically did, and matches GPS near the end.

On NASA's flights, each measured without its own data, holding the takeoff speed counted a median 68% of the distance and came within 10% on 7% of flights. The network counted a median 102% and came within 10% on 68% of flights; the store 104% and 65%. The two engines agree closely; the network, being smaller to ship and a little closer, is the one the app uses.

Figure 10 puts speed and direction together: the whole flight drawn from the first GPS point with nothing but what the phone senses. Both versions stay within about a kilometre of GPS through the taxi and the takeoff, a median 0.9 km over the whole recording. In the air the direction settles about 11° to one side of the track, and that, more than the speed, carries the drawn ends 16.1 km (network) and 15.5 km (store) from where GPS ended, about a fifth of the distance flown. The two versions draw nearly the same route: they share the direction and differ in speed by 3.5%.

5.7 A new phone

A new phone starts with the built-in network. On recordings it had never seen it missed by 9.1 km/h on a motorcycle and 6.6 km/h in a car, against 9.0 and 6.9 for the main model with a

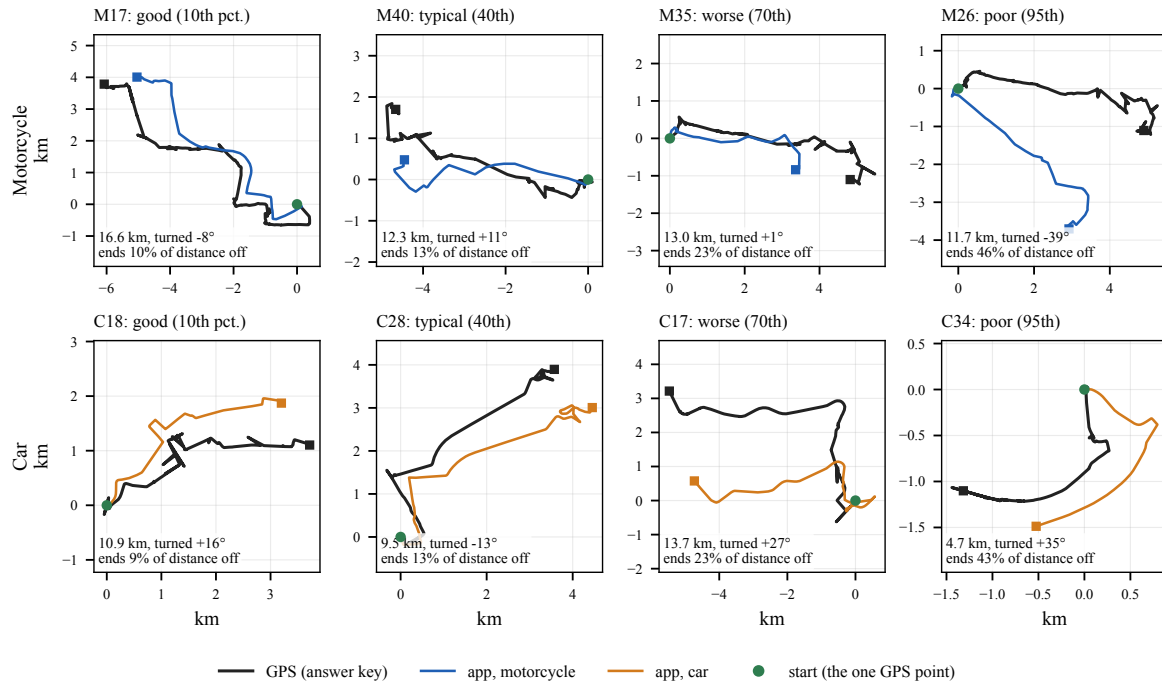


Figure 7. Eight routes drawn without GPS (colour) against GPS (black), chosen at the 10th, 40th, 70th and 95th percentile of end drift for each vehicle. Labels match Appendix A. To avoid revealing where they were recorded, each pair is turned together by an arbitrary angle, which leaves the comparison unchanged.

Table 6. What each part of the direction method adds: the share of graded seconds and of whole routes within 30° , routes turned more than 45° , and the flight's seconds within 30° . Each row adds one part to the row above. The magnetometer applies only where the magnetic field was recorded (three car drives so far; only on the first was it clean for long enough).

Direction method	Motorcycle		Car		Routes over 45°	Flight seconds
	Seconds	Routes	Seconds	Routes		
Heading + angle from turns	73%	83%	66%	71%	8	88%
+ drift at stops	71%	83%	71%	75%	8	99%
+ right, left apart	74%	85%	77%	79%	6	99%
+ turn explains push	75%	85%	78%	79%	6	99%
+ clean magnetometer	75%	85%	81%	79%	6	99%

full store, and counted 91.5% and 101.6% of the distance against 88.6% and 100.3% (Figure 11). A store still filling up does worse (Table 8): 11.1 km/h with 60 examples, 8.5 with 1,000 and 8.0 with 4,000, still a little behind the network's 7.9. The app hands over to the store at 3,000 examples all the same, because the store keeps adapting to the phone's own vehicle and pocket, an advantage these recordings, made with the same few vehicles the network was trained on, cannot show. Walking (103.7%) and the flight (102.9% and 103.0%) are nearly the same with either, since they are counted by steps and, in the air, by the flight engines.

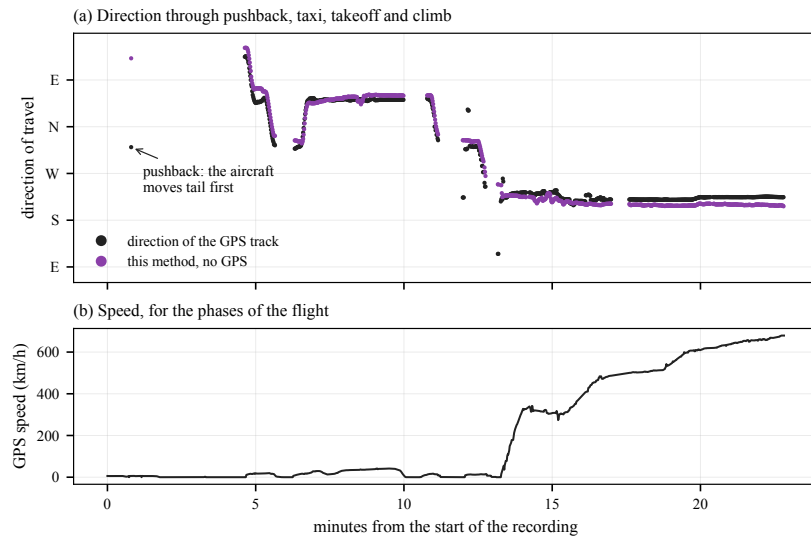


Figure 8. The flight, from the gate to the climb. (a) Direction of travel from the GPS track (black) and from this method, which uses no GPS (purple). (b) The aircraft's speed from GPS.

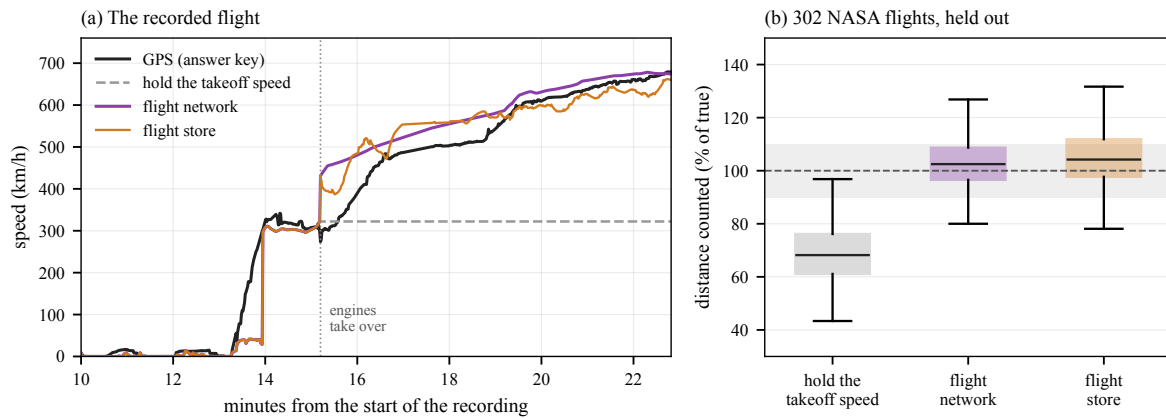


Figure 9. The flight engines. (a) The recorded flight: the takeoff is measured for two minutes, after which holding its speed (dashed) misses the climb while both engines follow it. (b) NASA flights, each measured by engines trained without it: the share of the distance from the start of the roll to landing that each counted; the box is the middle half, the whiskers the rest without outliers, the band within 10%.

Table 7. Speed in the air. Left: NASA flights, each measured by engines trained without it, from the start of the roll to landing. Right: the phone's flight through the app's own code. Speed errors are average km/h in the air (per flight, the median over flights).

In the air	302 NASA flights, held out				The phone's flight		
	Median distance	10th–90th pct.	Within 10%	Speed error	Distance km	Share of 74.1 km	Speed error
Hold the takeoff speed	68%	55–88%	7%	225	45.2	61%	196
Flight network	102%	91–118%	68%	82	76.2	103%	38
Flight store	104%	92–122%	65%	88	73.6	99%	37

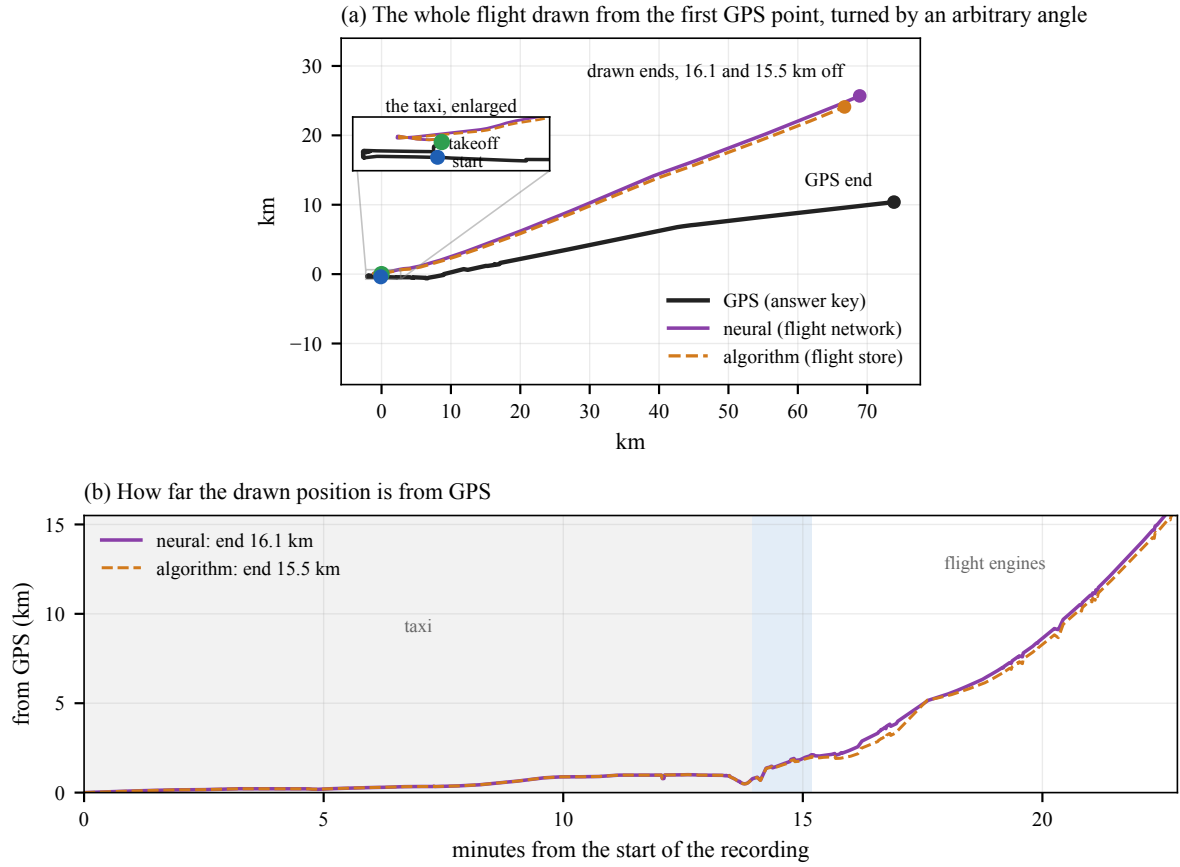


Figure 10. The whole flight drawn with no GPS after the first point. (a) GPS (black), the flight network (purple) and the flight store (orange, dashed). Like the routes in Figure 7 it is turned by an arbitrary angle so as not to show where it was recorded; the inset enlarges the taxi. (b) The distance between each drawn position and GPS's; grey is the taxi, blue the measured takeoff.

Table 8. A store still filling up against the built-in network, over motorcycle and car journeys together, with each journey's own examples left out.

Speed model	Average speed error (km/h)			Journeys	
	All	Motorcycle	Car	Distance	within 20%
Store, 60 examples	11.1	13.4	8.6	−24.4%	37%
Store, 150 examples	9.5	10.4	8.5	−9.2%	52%
Store, 300 examples	8.9	9.6	8.2	−2.6%	65%
Store, 1,000 examples	8.5	9.3	7.6	−4.8%	66%
Store, 2,000 examples	8.2	9.1	7.2	−8.1%	68%
Store, 3,000 examples	8.2	9.2	7.2	−8.8%	62%
Store, 4,000 examples	8.0	9.0	6.9	−5.7%	70%
Built-in network	7.9	9.1	6.6	−3.6%	77%

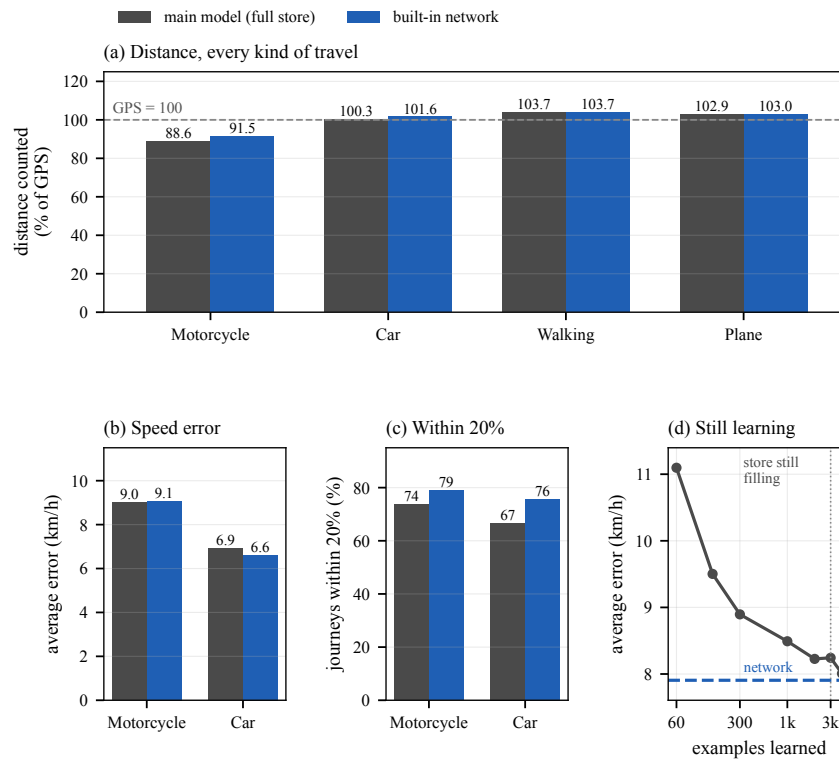


Figure 11. The built-in network (blue) next to the main model with a full store (grey), on the same journeys, the network only on recordings it had never seen. (a) Share of the GPS distance counted. (b) Average speed error. (c) Journeys within 20%. (d) A store still filling up; the dotted line is where the app hands over.

6 Discussion

6.1 Where it goes wrong

- **On a motorcycle, fast riding reads slow and slow riding reads fast.** Above 60 km/h the speed is under two-thirds of the true value (Table 2). Over a journey the two partly cancel, but a journey that is mostly fast comes out short.
- **A constant turn over a whole drive.** Much of the remaining direction error is one angle that lasts the whole drive: 26 of the 67 graded motorcycle and car recordings are turned by more than 15° on average. Removing one such turn per drive — which needs GPS, so it only bounds what is possible — would raise the share of seconds within 30° from 77% to 88% and more than halve the median error, from 16.5° to 7.5° . It comes from where the heading started and from the angle learned for the phone, and the replay cannot separate the two. On the one drive with a clean magnetic field the magnetometer cut it from 29° to 18° , and the seconds within 30° rose from 64% to 96%.
- **The first minute of a ride.** Until the angle of the phone is learned the direction comes from the heading alone (Figure 5). The redrawing fixes the saved route afterwards, but a very short ride may never learn the angle well.
- **A short, slow drive.** The angle is learned only while the speed model reads more than 14 km/h, so on a short drive in traffic it rests on a few turns, and which turns depends on the speed model. On the newest drive, ten minutes at a median 9 km/h, the speeds the app read on the day kept all 87 graded seconds within 30° of GPS; replayed with the speed model rebuilt from the other journeys, a different handful of turns set the angle and none were.
- **A phone that moves.** A hand shakes the phone and shaking reads as speed. A hand can no longer raise the speed, but a phone picked up while slowing keeps the speed it had when it was picked up. A phone that shifts in the pocket turns the drawn route by about as much as it moved, until enough new turns have been learned.
- **A magnet beside the phone.** By a car's MagSafe charger the phone read up to $2,600 \mu\text{T}$, fifty times Earth's field, yet reported its compass as well calibrated; the iPhone's own Compass then drifted 49° with the gyroscope. The app ignores such a field, but it cannot then correct the heading.
- **Car-park ramps and rides never recognised.** A car crawling up a concrete ramp shakes like one at 40 km/h, so distance is withheld while climbing and turning together; once that test fired on an ordinary road and dropped 9 seconds at 48 km/h, about 115 m. On one short ride Apple's classifier never said "driving" and the step counter took the engine for footsteps; as recorded, the app counted 1.0 of 2.4 km. Stretches counted by steps while GPS showed riding speed are left out of the comparisons (Section 4.5), so that ride is not among the graded ones.
- **In the air, a typical speed.** The flight engines give the speed an airliner of one type typically has at that point of a flight, not a measurement of this one. A headwind or tailwind, a faster or slower aircraft, a long hold or a short hop will make them read high or low: on NASA's flights the middle 80% counted 91 to 118% of the distance. Examples learned on the phone's own earlier flights with GPS take over when there are some, which one flight could not test. The direction in the air settled about 11° off the track, which carried the drawn end of the flight 16.1 km from GPS's (Figure 10).

Table 9. Approaches that were measured and did not do better, each on the recordings available when it was tried.

Approach	Idea	Measured against GPS
<i>Direction</i>		
Push when speeding up or braking	In a straight line the push points forward	44° off
Axis the motorcycle leans about	The lean axis follows the direction of travel	25° off
Direction of the rider's thigh	The thigh points forward while seated	73° off
Angle from turns without the speed	Weight each second by the change in turn rate	15–40° off on one drive
Angle from full physics	Add the speed model's change in speed to the turn	cars 80% → 48% within 30°
Square-root turn weights	Let the many small bends count more	a tie over 66 rides
Median instead of mean for drift	Ignore short bursts at stops	walking 93% → 88%
Looser stillness for drift	Measure drift at more stops	motorcycles 73% → 68%
Car magnetism fitted as a circle	Remove the car's own field from the magnetometer	no stable fit
<i>Walking, riding and the air</i>		
Thigh swing for walking direction	Swing is sharper forwards than backwards	wrong more often than right
Other riding-or-walking tests	A steady push; speed overruling steps	blocked 5% of real walking
Speed from turns in the air	Sideways push over turn rate	phone's turning hid the aircraft's
Integrating the whole climb	Carry the takeoff integration on	worked for one setting only
Cabin shaking as a fifth input	Shaking changes with height and speed	68% → 69% of NASA flights within 10%
<i>Speed</i>		
Last ten seconds into the network	More context for each answer	better per second, not per journey

6.2 What did not work

Table 9 lists approaches that were built and measured against GPS on the same recordings and did no better. Two are worth a note. Leaving the speed out of the angle learner seemed attractive, since it would make direction independent of the speed model, but a car brakes into a corner and accelerates out of it, and a learner driven by the change in turn rate adds the two up instead of cancelling them. And weighting turns by the square root of their push drew individual drives very differently, better on one and worse on another, yet over the 66 rides then recorded the learned angle was the same (9.5° against 9.2° median error): single drives are a poor guide to a method.

6.3 Lessons

- **The phone's own definitions caused more error than the models.** Its built-in heading becomes unreliable in a common pocket position, drifts in a car and can start wrong; its “user acceleration” points the opposite way to the vehicle's acceleration. Each of these, once found, mattered more than any change to the estimators.
- **GPS can hide in decisions as well as in distance.** The no-GPS mode never drew a

metre from GPS, yet at times it used GPS to decide between walking and riding, to set the first heading, or to carry an angle learned before the mode was switched on. Only reading every place the mode touched GPS found them.

- **Two errors can hide each other.** On one drive a worse angle estimate drew a better route, because it cancelled an error in the heading reference. Judge a part of the method against physics, not only by the route it draws.
- **A replay must do everything the app does,** stops and a phone in the hand included; with those rules in, it comes within about 5% of what the app drew.
- **A replay must feed each part what the app feeds it.** The flight's direction was at first replayed with the cabin's near-zero vibration speed rather than the speed the app has in the air. That starved the angle learner, and the result in the air swung between 4° and 24° with nothing but the replay's random choices; with the app's own speed it holds at $10\text{--}13^\circ$.
- **A replay's own randomness can move results.** When a recording was added, drawing every journey's store afresh moved numbers that had nothing to do with it by several points. Each example now keeps its own fixed chance of being drawn, so a new recording changes each store only by its own examples — which, small as they are, still move single journeys (Section 7).

7 Limitations

All recordings come from one person and one iPhone, mostly in one city, with a single flight; other people, phones and vehicles may behave differently, the starting network most of all. The flight engines learned from one aircraft of one regional jet type and were checked on the phone on a single flight of another; the phone measures tilt from gravity, which a steady push can bend, while the recorder measured the aircraft's attitude. Most results replay the newest method on earlier recordings rather than coming from live use, with a speed store drawn from the same person's other journeys; on a short drive the replayed and the live speeds can teach different angles (Section 6.1). Single journeys depend on the store's exact contents: adding the newest eight-minute drive changed about 1% of each journey's store and moved single journeys' distance by a median 3.6 points (up to 14), and the motorcycle and car totals by 0.3 and 1.3 points, so the shares of journeys within 20% move by several journeys from one re-run to the next. GPS in a pocket is accurate only to tens of metres, so small errors cannot be measured reliably. The magnetic field was recorded on three drives so far. On the first a MagSafe charger sat near the phone for part of the drive, on the second for all of it, and the field was clean for only 46 seconds, short of the minute the correction needs; on the third, with the phone placed away from the charger, the field still swung between 32 and 74 μT from minute to minute and was never clean.

8 Conclusion

A phone's own sensors can draw a usable route without satellites. Direction is the stronger half: learned from the vehicle's turns on a heading kept honest by its stops and, when possible, by the magnetometer, it stays within 30° of GPS most of the time on every kind of travel measured. Speed from vibration is close in a car and on foot but compressed on a motorcycle. In the air, the takeoff measured by the phone and then a network trained on public airline flight data counted the flight's distance to within 4%, where the takeoff alone counted 61%. The largest

remaining error is a constant turn over a whole drive, from where the heading started and from the angle learned for the phone, which so far only a clean magnetic field has been able to reduce.

Code and data. The app, including the method described here, is open source at <https://github.com/yu314-coder/GPS-location-app>. The recordings contain the author’s locations and are not published; the airline flight data is public [9], and the two flight engines ship with the app.

References

- [1] P. D. Groves. *Principles of GNSS, Inertial, and Multisensor Integrated Navigation Systems*, 2nd ed. Artech House, 2013.
- [2] V. Capuano, L. Xu and J. Estrada Benavides. Smartphone MEMS accelerometer and gyroscope measurement errors: laboratory testing and analysis of the effects on positioning performance. *Sensors*, 23(17):7609, 2023.
- [3] W. Li, R. Chen, Y. Yu, Y. Wu and H. Zhou. Pedestrian dead reckoning with novel heading estimation under magnetic interference and multiple smartphone postures. *Measurement*, 182:109610, 2021.
- [4] R. Harle. A survey of indoor inertial positioning systems for pedestrians. *IEEE Communications Surveys & Tutorials*, 15(3):1281–1293, 2013.
- [5] E. Foxlin. Pedestrian tracking with shoe-mounted inertial sensors. *IEEE Computer Graphics and Applications*, 25(6):38–46, 2005.
- [6] S. O. H. Madgwick, A. J. L. Harrison and R. Vaidyanathan. Estimation of IMU and MARG orientation using a gradient descent algorithm. In *Proc. IEEE International Conference on Rehabilitation Robotics*, pages 1–7, 2011.
- [7] M. B. Del Rosario, N. H. Lovell and S. J. Redmond. Quaternion-based complementary filter for attitude determination of a smartphone. *IEEE Sensors Journal*, 16(15):6008–6017, 2016.
- [8] B. Or. Learning-based speed estimation from accelerometer-only inertial sensing (CarSpeedNet). arXiv:2401.07468, 2024.
- [9] NASA Ames Research Center. Flight data for tail 687. DASHlink, <https://c3.ndc.nasa.gov/dashlink/>.

A Every journey

Each motorcycle (M) and car (C) journey, in the order recorded, with no dates. Minutes and GPS km are what GPS could check; app/GPS is the distance ratio for journeys of at least 1 km; speed error is the average over half-minutes; direction is graded where at least 50 seconds could be; the route columns are the whole-route comparison. A dash means too little GPS to grade.

	Min.	GPS km	App/GPS (%)	Speed err. (km/h)	Dir. within 30° (%)	Dir. median (°)	Route km	Turned (°)	Size
M01	9	2.0	104	4.4	–	–	–	–	–
M02	20	4.0	83	7.7	68	9	11.9	+1	0.58
M03	14	4.8	109	6.3	82	21	7.3	+14	0.96
M04	23	6.7	99	7.9	60	26	11.9	+24	0.91
M05	18	5.7	99	9.6	83	14	9.5	-13	0.90
M06	18	8.2	85	11.6	90	7	12.0	-4	1.00
M07	16	5.8	89	8.2	89	21	8.0	-23	0.86
M08	–	–	–	–	–	–	2.5	-56	0.55
M09	4	1.4	103	3.8	93	5	2.0	-9	0.87
M10	14	6.1	78	8.0	44	32	7.3	+30	0.76
M11	19	6.2	100	8.3	91	6	9.3	-12	0.78

	Min.	GPS km	App/GPS (%)	Speed err. (km/h)	Dir. within 30° (%)	Dir. median (°)	Route km	Turned (°)	Size
M12	15	3.6	102	7.6	78	17	8.8	+8	0.76
M13	10	2.4	113	7.6	85	8	5.7	+8	0.84
M14	11	2.3	79	6.9	80	9	6.5	-1	0.74
M15	20	3.5	91	9.3	86	7	12.0	-8	0.97
M16	9	3.5	100	6.6	97	4	4.1	-2	1.12
M17	27	9.7	87	9.5	83	12	16.6	-8	0.84
M18	—	—	—	—	—	—	2.7	-99	0.36
M19	14	2.0	106	6.6	64	18	8.0	-5	1.62
M20	8	2.8	91	9.3	92	7	4.0	-10	0.80
M21	9	0.3	—	1.1	23	56	3.2	-32	0.47
M22	25	7.9	67	11.5	64	17	15.6	-14	0.74
M23	11	3.6	96	8.5	50	30	4.3	-28	0.83
M24	—	—	—	—	85	14	—	—	—
M25	15	1.4	107	6.0	94	5	5.1	+2	0.51
M26	32	6.8	92	5.9	52	30	11.7	-39	0.88
M27	12	2.6	98	6.2	65	17	6.0	-9	1.18
M28	19	6.3	101	11.6	86	10	13.9	+7	0.80
M29	21	4.1	91	4.9	72	20	11.5	-29	0.76
M30	8	3.1	96	8.3	74	24	5.7	-13	1.08
M31	—	—	—	—	22	53	1.7	+61	1.05
M32	27	5.7	76	10.3	57	21	13.1	-4	0.85
M33	20	4.9	103	13.5	83	15	10.4	-17	1.09
M34	20	5.6	89	9.7	80	10	10.3	-2	0.92
M35	20	5.8	67	13.0	83	10	13.0	+1	0.64
M36	12	5.0	36	24.1	86	23	6.6	+22	0.41
M37	20	3.5	83	9.3	43	38	9.9	-24	0.63
M38	17	1.4	36	6.5	63	14	5.1	+10	0.70
M39	16	1.3	157	6.5	81	17	4.8	-6	0.65
M40	19	4.1	108	8.8	44	34	12.3	+11	0.82
M41	20	5.8	78	10.9	85	17	8.5	+6	0.74
M42	24	7.4	76	10.0	69	22	13.8	-21	0.98
M43	27	9.2	88	10.4	89	13	14.7	-14	0.91
C01	10	2.5	95	2.3	48	31	2.8	-26	0.89
C02	15	2.2	92	3.2	96	10	2.8	+9	0.94
C03	11	0.0	—	1.0	—	—	—	—	—
C04	13	2.0	105	3.0	100	5	2.7	-3	1.02
C05	32	9.2	96	4.4	98	12	11.0	+1	0.87
C06	34	10.0	97	2.9	96	16	11.2	-16	0.95
C07	10	1.3	99	2.8	0	58	1.7	-56	0.98
C08	8	1.7	102	3.1	79	10	2.1	-17	0.90
C09	11	6.6	111	8.8	—	—	—	—	—
C10	16	7.6	130	10.8	—	—	—	—	—
C11	14	8.1	140	22.4	—	—	—	—	—
C12	9	2.7	83	9.9	—	—	—	—	—
C13	13	6.5	65	16.7	—	—	—	—	—
C14	24	7.5	85	9.7	—	—	—	—	—
C15	16	6.5	76	11.7	—	—	—	—	—
C16	29	6.0	121	6.6	—	—	—	—	—
C17	25	9.5	83	8.1	64	18	13.7	+27	0.67
C18	24	7.4	63	10.0	89	16	10.9	+16	0.97
C19	3	0.8	—	3.2	100	6	1.6	+10	1.13
C20	21	6.5	116	6.3	97	5	9.0	-4	1.12
C21	12	3.5	117	4.6	98	5	4.4	-5	1.20
C22	10	2.5	95	2.9	91	23	3.2	+33	0.89
C23	12	2.6	100	3.1	64	26	3.1	-27	0.88

	Min.	GPS km	App/GPS (%)	Speed err. (km/h)	Dir. within 30° (%)	Dir. median (°)	Route km	Turned (°)	Size
C24	10	1.3	136	7.2	99	18	2.1	+12	1.02
C25	6	1.1	63	5.4	59	12	1.6	+13	1.08
C26	7	0.9	–	5.1	–	–	2.0	+44	1.27
C27	8	1.1	142	5.1	90	20	2.7	+27	0.96
C28	19	7.8	107	6.6	96	15	9.5	-13	0.98
C29	6	1.2	124	5.9	70	22	2.5	+13	0.95
C30	15	9.1	90	6.2	98	17	10.4	-11	0.97
C31	25	13.6	98	5.6	82	27	16.3	-25	0.97
C32	8	1.1	174	10.4	97	10	1.8	+12	1.14
C33	4	0.9	–	8.2	67	10	1.2	+46	1.00
C34	15	3.0	90	4.6	43	33	4.7	+35	0.97
C35	12	4.3	115	5.2	99	8	4.9	+10	1.11
C36	11	1.9	109	3.4	99	9	2.9	-8	1.09
C37	18	5.5	97	2.7	1	64	6.5	+64	0.97

B Settings

Table 11. Every setting of the method as evaluated.

Setting	Value
<i>Speed</i>	
Vibration window for one fingerprint	5 s at 50 Hz, 11 numbers
Store of the phone’s own examples	up to 4,000
Neighbours averaged	12
Built-in network	11 → 32 → 32 → 1; used until the store holds 3,000
Network refuses a fingerprint	farther from all training clusters than 99.5% of training data
Takeoff integration in the air	from the last still moment, up to 120 s
Flight engines, after the takeoff	time since the roll; tilt over 60 s, 300 s and since the roll
Flight network	4 → 32 → 32 → 1, trained on 302 NASA flights
Flight store	4,000 NASA examples, 12 neighbours, weights $1/d^2$
<i>Direction</i>	
Riding begins	9 km/h (2.5 m/s)
Learning the phone’s angle	above 14 km/h (4 m/s); turn explains $\geq 10\%$ of the push
First estimate	after 30 s and a summed speed $\times$ turn rate of 20 m/s ²
Redrawing a ride	when the angle moves $\geq 3^\circ$, at most every 10 s
A new ride	after 20 s without riding
A phone taken out of the pocket	angle forgotten after 10 s in the hand
Drift measured at stops	stopped, turning < 0.005 rad/s, hand-rotation < 0.2 rad/s
Drift estimate	after 30 still seconds, 10-minute memory, at most $3^\circ/\text{min}$
Clean magnetic field	25–65 μT , strength and dip steady to 3 over 60 s
Magnetometer correction	60 clean seconds in the last 20 min, spread $< 15^\circ$
Walking direction window	4 s